



Informal Reports

Chapter 10

10 Key Points:

1. Informal Reports for Routine Issues
2. Pertinent Information
3. Distinguish reports by purpose, frequency & format
4. Direct Approach
5. Indirect Approach
6. Heading
7. 3 Step Process for Successful Report
8. Visual Aid
9. Informational Report
10. Analytical Report

1. Informal Reports for Routine Issues

- ▶ Short report
- ▶ Memo/letter format
- ▶ Casual language
- ▶ Less structure than formal reports
 - ▶ No table of content
 - ▶ No heading for introduction

2. Include only pertinent information

- ▶ Characteristics of an informal report:
- ▶ Content
 - ▶ Only pertinent (relevant) information
 - ▶ Relevant to the intended audience
- ▶ Clarity
 - ▶ Proper English
 - ▶ Use of visual aids
 - ▶ Chronological
- ▶ Skimmability 

3. Distinguish reports by purpose, frequency and format

- ▶ Purpose
 - ▶ Informational
 - ▶ Analytical
 - ▶ Recommendation
- ▶ Frequency of submission
 - ▶ Periodic
 - ▶ One-time
- ▶ Format
 - ▶ Memorandum
 - ▶ Prepared form
 - ▶ Letter
 - ▶ Powerpoint

3. Common categories:



Informational report		Analytical/recommendation report
Incident	Job completion	Recommendation
Investigative	Incident	Justification
Progress	Summary	Feasibility
Activity	Trip	Comparison

4. Direct Approach

- Deductive Argument  
- Neutral or Positive Audience
- Main idea on the top, followed by the evidence

4. Advantages



1. Time-saving
2. Easy to follow
3. More forceful

4. Limitation

- ▶ Ineffective for “skeptical, hostile or resist the recommendation” audience

4. Example of Direct Approach

Title Page	• This should include the title of the report (which should give a precise indication of the subject matter), the author's name, module, course and the date.
Synopsis	• Statement of the problem • Scope and limitations • General findings • Purpose
Recommendations	• List in order of importance
Body/Discussion	• Background • Methods used • Results obtained • Analysis of results
Summary	• State the theme of each section • Link themes together
Conclusions	• Relate to recommendations • Support recommendations • Use the same order as recommendations

5. Indirect Approach

1. Inductive Argument 
2. Scientific Writing
3. Evidence first, followed by main points

5. Advantages



1. Showing negative information
2. Subordinating the judgment to the audience

5. Limitations

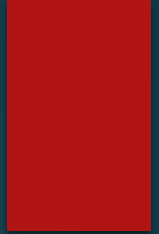


1. Hard to follow
2. Lacking confidence
3. Lack of judgment

5. Example

Executive Summary	• This should be a short paragraph summarizing the main contents of the report. It should include a short statement of the main task, the methods used, conclusions reached and recommendations. • The abstract or summary should be concise, informative and independent of the report. • Write this section after you have written the report.
Introduction	• The introduction comes next. It prepares the reader by giving background on the subject, explaining the method by which you arrived at your findings, defining technical terms if necessary, and/or explaining limitations. Generally, the more widely a report is to be circulated, the lengthier the introduction.
Body/Discussion	• Your findings will be in the body of the report. The way you organize the sequence of ideas will depend on the subject and your purpose.

Direct & Indirect Approach



1. Conclusion
2. Tips:
 - ▶ Use Opening Statements
 - ▶ Soften Negative Information
 - ▶ Stick to the point

6. Headings

- ▶ Gives overview of lengthy text
- ▶ Catches readers attention
- ▶ Gives readers direction
- ▶ Narrows down the search for information
- ▶ Time saving

6. 3 Types of Heading



1. Question heading:
Question
2. Statement heading:
Expression or Statement
3. Topic heading:
One or Few Words

6. Tip for Heading

- ▶ Representative of the text
- ▶ Visually appealing
- ▶ Formal and professional

7. 3 Step Process for Successful Report

1. Planning
2. Researching & Analyzing Data and Information
3. Composing & revising

7. 1. Planning

- ▶ Setting a time length
- ▶ Estimating a budget
- ▶ Distributing resources
- ▶ Creating a setup
- ▶ Separating the task

7. 2. Researching

- ▶ Finding key points
- ▶ Searching up main points
- ▶ Extend knowledge
- ▶ Understand the concept better
- ▶ Finding arguments

7. 2. Analyzing Data and Information

- ▶ Look for valid sources
- ▶ Find information from reliable sources
- ▶ Check the reliability of each source
- ▶ Check its accuracy and date to make sure of it's validity
- ▶ Cite the sites

7. 3. Composition

- ▶ Compose arguments
- ▶ Bring out the information in an impactful way
- ▶ Regroup similar ideas
- ▶ Use headings
- ▶ Be as accurate
- ▶ Cut down extra information

7. 3. Revision

- ▶ Revise after few days
- ▶ Ask a colleague to skim through it
- ▶ Auto-correct it
- ▶ Less mistake equals more effective report

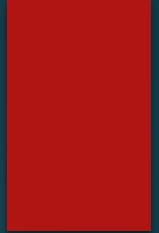
Questions



Which step do each belong to:

1. Regroup similar ideas
2. Distributing resources
3. Finding key points

8. Visual Aids



- ▶ They're easy to learn, but hard to master!
- ▶ These are the “Do's and Don'ts” of creating a Visual Aid

8. Do's

- ▶ Use fonts and colors to emphasize evidence.
- ▶ Consider clarity, space, purpose and tone when choosing a font
- ▶ Incorporate the colors of the company's logo, avoid dark backgrounds and test all colors

8. Don'ts

- ▶ Make sure lines move appropriately on the bar-chart.
- ▶ Create a logical flow of data.
- ▶ Never omit percentages, never move counter clockwise, and minimize “slices” in a pie chart.

9. Informational Report



This type of report collects data and presents findings.

- ▶ Who wants the report, and why?
- ▶ Gather and cite authoritative data. Explain how you obtained any primary sources.

9. Informational reports (suite)

Three sections: Introduction, Findings, and Summary/Conclusion

- ▶ Capture the reader's attention and introduce purpose.
- ▶ Demonstrate your findings.
- ▶ Briefly summarize and conclude.

10. Analytical Report



This type of report analyzes information with the goal of determining a course of action.

- ▶ You need to generate your own content here, unlike in the Informational report.
- ▶ Use the indirect method of communication to allow the recipient a gradual understanding of your point.

10. Analytical Report (suite)

- ▶ Who, what, where, when, why and how?
- ▶ Introduce the plan, argue your stance, explain the benefits, elaborate on the plan, then summarize and conclude.

Case Study



Context:

- ▶ Write a progress report
- ▶ Our teams acts as a Chief contractor
- ▶ Address the report to our client (Hilary Murdoch)

Case Study Solution



- ▶ Use memo format
- ▶ Introduction
- ▶ Work completed
- ▶ Work in progress
- ▶ Work to be completed
- ▶ Conclusion
- ▶ Regards

Bibliography



- ▶ "3 Types of Headings." Daily Writing Tips. N.p., n.d. Web. 16 Nov. 2014. From
▶ <<http://www.dailywritingtips.com/3-types-of-headings/>> .
- ▶ "Writing Skills." *Writing the Report: The Essential Stages*. N.p., n.d. Web. 18 Nov. 2014. From
▶ <http://libweb.surrey.ac.uk/library/skills/writing%20Skills%20Leicester/page_77.htm>
- ▶ Bovée, Courtland L., John V. Thill, and Barbara E. Schatzman. *Business Communication Today*. Boston: Pearson Custom Pub., 2003.
Print. <<http://faculty.winthrop.edu/kosterj/writ465/management/directapproach.htm>>
- ▶ "Disadvantages of the Indirect Approach in Report Writing." EHow. Demand Media, 01 Apr. 2011. Web. 18 Nov. 2014. <http://www.ehow.com/info_8147825_disadvantages-indirect-approach-report-writing.html>
- ▶ "Tips on Writing Direct and Indirect Business Email." EHow. Demand Media, 10 July 2009. Web. 18 Nov. 2014.
▶ <<http://smallbusiness.chron.com/tips-writing-direct-indirect-business-email-4008.html>>
- ▶ "Report Proposal Writing." *Report Proposal Writing*. N.p., n.d. Web. 18 Nov. 2014.
▶ <<https://www.uvic.ca/hr/assets/docs/ld/self-learning-guides/report-proposal-writing.pdf>>
- ▶ Hurley. (2009, January 1). Writing Informational and Analytical Reports. Retrieved November 6, 2014, From
▶ <http://emedia.leeward.hawaii.edu/hurley/modules/mod4/4_docs/reports.pdf>
- ▶ Pfeiffer, W., & Pfeiffer, W. (2001). Graphics. In *Technical Writing: A practical approach* (pp. 397-451). Upper Saddle River, NJ: Pearson/Prentice Hall.
- ▶ Saga, M. (n.d.). How to Prepare & Write an Informational Report | The Classroom | Synonym. Retrieved November 5, 2014,
▶ <http://classroom.synonym.com/prepare-write-informational-report-2403.html>